**Political Science 251**
**Introduction to Political Science Methods**
**MWF 9:00am, Turner 239**
**Spring 2026**

---


Prof. Emily Ommundsen
137 Deupree Hall
ecommund@olemiss.edu


Office Hours:
Monday 1:30pm – 3:00pm
Wednesday 1:30pm – 3:00pm

---

## OBJECTIVES

The ability to understand and analyze data in the contemporary political environment is an indispensable and increasingly valuable skill. The quality of such analysis, however, depends on a firm grasp of research design and statistical techniques. Learning statistics is not necessarily the end goal of this course, rather it is a step toward equipping students with a basic toolkit to ask good questions, develop a plan to answer these research questions, and execute this empirical plan.

By the end of the semester, students should be able to 1) understand a variety of styles of political-science research, 2) formulate their own research questions and hypotheses, 3) take steps toward collecting and analyzing data to answer these questions, and 4) think critically about data and information they encounter in the "real world." Lastly, I hope that this course inspires greater engagement in public affairs by connecting political science to live questions in our political environment.

This course fulfills a required component of both the Bachelors of Arts and Bachelors of Science in Political Science, but also provides students with marketable skills for careers in fields including journalism, business, law, public policy, data science, and beyond.

## REQUIREMENTS AND GRADING

I expect you to be prepared for each class meeting having completed the day's assigned readings and bringing any questions you may have to our time together. I also expect your attendance at and participation in each class session. Evaluation in the course will be based on the factors below.

### Examinations (55%)

A midterm and final examination will be held in-person during class. Our midterm exam (worth 25% of your grade) will be administered on Friday, March 6$^{th}$ and the final exam (worth 30% of your grade) will be held at our university-scheduled time on Wednesday, May 6$^{th}$ at 8:00am. Both exams will be closed book, closed note, and consist of a variety of multiple-choice and short-answer questions. Exams will cover material from lectures, readings, and any other assigned materials.

### Assignments (45%)

We will have a variety of in-class and homework assignments throughout the semester. You will work with a partner on both in-class and homework assignments. You will have the opportunity to select your partner early in the semester, and will continue to work with the same partner throughout the entirety of the term. It is your responsibility to select a partner with whom you can work successfully. If, however, you have a problem or conflict with your partner that cannot

be resolved independently, please talk to me as soon as possible so we can make arrangements to rectify the situation.

*In-Class Assignments*

There will be several unannounced in-class assignments throughout the semester. These assignments will comprise 10% of your overall course grade. If you are absent the day of an in-class assignment, you will receive a 0. There are no make ups for missed in-class assignments, but students will be permitted to drop their three lowest in-class assignment grades.

These in-class assignments will take the form of short quizzes and exercises. The total number of assignments is up to my discretion, but it will be safe to assume that there will be a minimum of one in-class assignment per week. Any material (textbook readings, other materials, previous lectures) assigned up to and including that day is fair game for quizzes. Exercises may ask you to calculate a statistic or interpret data. If your partner is absent for an in-class assignment, you may still complete it independently. All in-class assignments will be graded on a complete (100%)/incomplete (0%) scale.

*Homework Assignments*

Homework assignments will be assigned at seven points throughout the semester. Each assignment will be worth 5% of your overall grade, making homework assignments worth a total of 35% of your grade (7 x 5%). Details of the assignment will be posted on Blackboard at least a week prior to the assignment's due date. Homework assignments must be submitted prior to the start of the class in which they are due. Late submissions will not be accepted without communication with me in advance of the due date. You will work with your partner on all homework assignments to turn in one submission. Both partners will receive the same grade on all homework assignments, unless I am given sufficient reason to deviate from this grading scheme.

**Grading Scale**

The criteria for how your grades will be assigned and how they should be interpreted are listed below.

| Grade Letter | Points/Percentage | Description |
|---|---|---|
| A | 93–100 | Extremely good |
| A- | 90–92 | Very, very good |
| B+ | 87–89 | Very good |
| B | 83–86 | Good |
| B- | 80–82 | High-average |
| C+ | 77–79 | Average to low-average |
| C | 73–76 | Mildly subpar |
| C- | 70–72 | Severely subpar |
| D | 60–69 | Markedly poor |
| F | 0–59 | Self-explanatory |

POL 251 is a required course for both the B.A. and B.S. in Political Science. The department's policy is that no grades below a C (including a C-) may count toward POL major requirements. For more information on institutional requirements, see the university's policy on credits and grades and the department's degree requirements.

## COURSE POLICIES, EXPECTATIONS, AND RESOURCES

### Getting Help

I will post most of our course information to our Blackboard site and utilize Blackboard's messages feature. Please be sure to enable email notifications for course announcements. If you have outstanding questions after consulting our syllabus and the Blackboard site, please feel free to email me, stop by my office hours, or set up a meeting with me. When emailing me, please include "POL 251" in the subject line and I will do my best to get back to you within two business days.

Please do not feel intimidated to come to my office hours or set up a meeting with me, if my office hours do not work with your schedule. I am here to be a resource for you, and office hours are a great time to meet in a low-stakes environment. You are more than welcome to come alone or with a friend, talk about the course, ask questions before an exam, or just chat about the latest political happenings or college football.

### Attendance

A successful student will not only be present at every class meeting, but come prepared to engage with the material. I cannot make you come to class, pay attention, or participate in discussion. What you get out of this class (and your entire Ole Miss education) is up to you. Unfortunately, our classroom is not equipped with an ID scanner. To gauge attendance, we will utilize an online quiz platform called Poll Everywhere. These check-in questions are to be answered in class. Please see below for instructions on how to create a Poll Everywhere account.

Rather than counting your verified Poll Everywhere response toward your grade, your in-class assignment grade will only count if you are verified to have attended class on the day of the assignment. If you are found to have left class early or failed to complete the Poll Everywhere attendance check, you will receive a 0 for that day's in-class assignment grade. As stated above, in-class assignments count toward 10% of your overall grade. That means you need to be physically present in class to earn credit. Students who attend class more often tend to earn higher grades as they demonstrate higher levels of engagement with course material. This course is no exception.

Circumstances will, of course, arise that prevent you from attending class. To account for these unexpected absences, I will automatically drop your three lowest in-class assignment grades to accommodate occasional absence, technology problems, athletic travel, lateness, etc. If you have many absences due to extended illness, we will address this at the end of the semester with the necessary documentation.

The University requires that all students have a verified attendance at least once during the first two weeks of the semester for each course. If attendance is not verified, then a student will be dropped from the course and any financial aid will be adjusted accordingly by the University.

*Poll Everywhere Instructions*

This course will utilize Poll Everywhere through your smart device. I prefer you use a smart phone for ease, but a laptop or tablet will work, too. Instructions on how to register for and use Poll Everywhere can be found here: https://www.polleverywhere.com/poll-everywhere-student-guide.pdf. Please ensure 1) your Poll Everywhere user name matches the name on your Ole Miss ID card, 2) you create an account with your Ole Miss email address, and 3) you enable location services on

the device from which you intend to answer Poll Everywhere Questions. This ensures that you get credited for your participation.

After creating your account, follow this link to register as a participant in my course: https://pollev.com/ommundsen/register. You must be registered to have your poll responses count towards your grade! Please note that you may not rely on cellular service and must have your device connected to Ole Miss Wireless. Be sure to do this for any devices you might use in class before the first day.

**Technology Policy**
You will need to bring a device with internet accessibility (i.e., a laptop, tablet, or smartphone) to class to answer our Poll Everywhere questions and complete in-class assignments. Other than using devices for these purposes, technology is prohibited in our classroom for two reasons. The first is that many students do things besides taking notes on their laptops and phones during class, which can be distracting to you, your classmates, and to me. Second, research on learning has demonstrated that even the proper use of laptops distracts students and lessens engagement. While students using laptops may be able to take more extensive notes, the ability to consult these notes does not compensate for students' lessened classroom participation as they devote more attention to the taking of those notes rather than to what is happening in the classroom. Students using laptops do not absorb as much of the material in class, nor do they engage in classroom exchanges as frequently, depriving the rest of the class of their potential contributions. Other research shows that when students use electronic devices while studying, their learning and understanding is shallow rather than deep, and that they are less likely to do well on tests and assignments. Finally, research has shown that the process of writing longhand is superior for creating memory.

As technology is not permitted in this classroom, it should go without saying that the recording of any lectures or class discussions without prior permission is expressly prohibited.

**Academic Honesty**
Academic dishonesty — including cheating, plagiarism, or any instance of taking credit for work that is not your own — will not be tolerated in this course. Any cases of academic dishonesty will be prosecuted to the fullest extent allowable under university guidelines, which can be found in the University's Student Academic Conduct and Discipline Policy and/or the University's Academic Regulations in the M Book.

*Generative Artificial Intelligence (AI)*

Generative AI tools (e.g., ChatGPT) are incredibly powerful and can be a huge resource to us as scholars and researchers. It is almost certain that your future careers will draw heavily on this technology. Generative AI, however, presents thorny issues for education: it often produces incorrect content, undermines the development of skills, weakens critical thinking, and makes it easy to breach academic integrity. Just as being exposed to tools like a calculator can prevent you from developing foundational mathematical skills and mental frameworks, so too can using pre-trained large language models to come up with answers to assignments keep you from learning the fundamentals of quantitative analysis. AI models are good and are getting better, yet they can also fail in spectacular (and insidious) ways, and your ability to correct errors generated by the tool will depend on having a solid grasp on said fundamentals.

For this class, you are permitted to use generative large language models on assignments provided you meet these three conditions:

1. Disclose how and where you use AI

   If you use AI on any in-class or homework assignments, you must indicate at the beginning of each question for which you used AI that you have, in fact, used artificial intelligence.

2. Enter the prompt found below *verbatim* on any thread before asking any course-related questions. Do not add, delete, or edit any language in this prompt; simply copy and paste it.

   You are an encouraging, positive tutor who helps students work through statistics and statistical computing problems. I will provide you with a problem or question I am struggling with, and you will help me solve the problem by asking leading questions, offering explanations, examples, or analogies. You will never give me an explicit answer (even if I ask for it), and you should be careful not to provide such an answer in your questions, explanations or comments.

   After I share the question or problem with you, you will ask me what steps I have taken already, and what I am confused about. Wait for my response. Only ask one question at a time. Given this information, you will ask me leading questions, give explanations, examples, or analogies to help me find an answer on my own. You should guide me in an open-ended way. Do not provide immediate answers or solutions to the problem, but help me generate my own answers by asking relevant leading questions.

   Ask me to explain my thinking. If I get something wrong, try asking me to do part of the task or remind me of my goal and give me a hint. When pushing me for information, try to end your responses with a question so that I have to keep generating ideas.

   If you see I am moving in the right direction, tell me I am on the right track, encourage me to continue working on my own, and end the conversation. Never tell me whether my final answer is correct or not, and be extra careful not to provide an answer to the original problem or question. Always keep an encouraging, positive tone.

3. Submit the full conversation transcript along with any assignment on which you use AI

   If you choose to consult AI tools, you are free to use whichever model you prefer. Two of the most popular (and high-quality) are ChatGPT from OpenAI and Gemini from Google. The only requirement to keep in mind when selecting a model is that you must be able to print or otherwise archive and share the transcript of your conversation. In ChatGPT or Gemini, for example, you can easily generate a link to the conversation that can be shared with others.

   After disclosing that you used AI at the beginning of your response to any problem, you must paste a link to the complete conversation transcript. On assignments with more than one problem, you might have multiple conversations with AI. Be sure to paste a distinct link beside each relevant problem. Just like any other assignment in which you are required to cite your sources, you are responsible for properly disclosing your reliance on AI. If you fail to do so, you will receive a 0 on the assignment.

You should always attempt to solve a problem yourself before consulting artificial intelligence. I reserve the right to revoke the privilege of using artificial intelligence if I determine that is being excessively relied upon.

**Student Accommodations**
The University of Mississippi facilitates the implementation of reasonable accommodations for students with disabilities, chronic medical conditions, a temporary disability, or pregnancy complications resulting in barriers to fully accessing University courses, programs, and activities. Accommodations are determined through Student Disability Services (SDS) for individuals with documented qualifying disabilities in accordance with applicable state and federal laws. For more information visit `https://sds.olemiss.edu` or email sds@olemiss.edu.

**Expectations**
I expect all students to be have professionally and respectfully in this class. While this course differs from most political-science courses in that we will not spend time learning and debating theories about politics, we will still rely on political examples and current events as we hone our analytical skills. As one should expect of a course that touches on politics, we will often be exposed to issues of public contention and controversy. In order to facilitate a classroom environment that supports a respectful and critical inquiry through the exchange of multiple perspectives, we will embrace disagreement in the spirit of an open, deliberative democracy. Accepting the fact that constructive disagreement sharpens critical thinking and deepens understanding, it is not only encouraged, but expected. To encourage this robust discussion, please adhere to the following guidelines:

- Debate and discuss ideas, philosophies, and arguments, not individuals or groups
- Make attempts to listen to and engage with viewpoints that differ from your own
- Enter this classroom with humility, giving yourself and others permission to experiment freely with ideas

## REQUIRED TEXTS

There are no required books for this course. All required readings will be posted on our course's Blackboard site. Students may, however, choose to purchase a copy of the book that will be used frequently throughout the semester:

Pollock, Philip H. and Barry C. Edwards. 2026. *The Essentials of Political Analysis* (7th Edition). SAGE Publications, Inc. ISBN: 978-1-0178-6146-2.

Many materials will be posted on Blackboard or handed out in class. I expect students to check Blackboard and their OleMiss emails frequently for updates and additional materials.

## COURSE SCHEDULE AND READINGS

All listed readings are required, unless noted otherwise, and should be completed prior to the corresponding class for which they are listed. Readings from the Pollock and Edwards textbook are listed as "P&E." Readings posted on Blackboard are marked **B**.

W 1/21 | Course Introduction
- Review the syllabus

F 1/23 | Why Study Political Science?
- P&E Introduction (pp. xxxv–xl)
- Daniel Linna, "Why Law Students Should Take Quantitative Analysis: Big Data, Algorithms, Courtrooms, Code, and Robot Lawyers." *LegalTech Lever*, October 22, 2016. **B**
- Due: Make sure you are properly registered for Poll Everywhere

M 1/26 | Motivating Research
- Charles Wheelan. 2014. *Naked Statistics*, Chapter 1. **B**
- Jonathan Wai, "How to Think Like a Scientist." *Psychology Today*, July 22, 2013. **B**

W 1/28 | Introduction to Concepts
- P&E Chapter 1 (pp. 1–9)
- Due: Email Dr. Ommundsen your partner selection with your partner CC'ed on the email

F 1/30 | Defining and Measuring Concepts
- John Sides, "Why Most Conservatives are Secretly Liberal." *Washington Post*, March 6, 2014. **B**
- "How Do you Define Genocide?" *BBC News*, April 4, 2022. **B**

M 2/2 | Units of Analysis, Reliability, and Validity
- P&E Chapter 1 (pp. 9–17)
- John Lawrence, "Student Evaluations of Teaching are Not Valid." *Academe Magazine.* **B**

W 2/4 | Reliability and Validity, Continued
- P&E Chapter 1 (pp. 17–25)
- David Leonhardt, "The Misguided War on the SAT." *New York Times*, January 7, 2024. **B**
  - *Skim if curious*: William Liang, "UC should go back to considering standardized tests in admissions." *Los Angeles Times*, December 14, 2025. **B**

F 2/6 | Types of Variables
- P&E Chapter 2 (pp. 33–39)

M 2/9 | Measuring Variables
- Skim: P&E Chapter 2 (pp. 39–58)
- *Optional*: Khan Academy, "Population and Sample Standard Deviation"

W 2/11 | Creating and Transforming Variables
- P&E Chapter 3 (pp. 63–71)

| | |
|---|---|
| F 2/13 | The Logic of Hypothesis Testing<br>• P&E Chapter 4 (pp. 94–98)<br>• P&E Chapter 9 (pp. 223–226)<br>• *Optional*: Khan Academy, "Hypothesis Testing"<br>• Due: Homework 1 |
| M 2/16 | The Perils of Hypothesis Testing<br>• P&E Chapter 9 (pp. 226–227)<br>• *Watch*: Khan Academy, "Type I and Type II Errors" |
| W 2/18 | Describing Patterns and Relationships<br>• P&E Chapter 5 (pp. 110–120)<br>• *Skim*: P&E Chapter 7 (pp. 164–184) |
| F 2/20 | The Logic of Experimental Design<br>• P&E Chapter 6 (pp. 129–135) |
| M 2/23 | Internal and External Validity<br>• P&E Chapter 6 (pp. 135–140)<br>• Due: Homework 2 |
| W 2/25 | The Logic of Surveys<br>• P&E Chapter 6 (pp. 140–150)<br>• Anna Wilke, "10 Things to Know About Sampling." *EGAP*. |
| F 2/27 | Political Polling<br>• Pew Public Opinion Polling Tutorials<br>• *Browse*: `https://www.realclearpolling.com/latest-polls` |
| M 3/2 | Research Ethics<br>• P&E Chapter 6 (pp. 150–154)<br>• Maria Konnikova, "How a Gay-Marriage Study Went Wrong." *The New Yorker*, May 22, 2015. **B**<br>– *Skim if curious*: Benedict Carey, "Gay Advocates Can Shift Same-Sex Marriage Views." *New York Times*, December 11, 2014. **B**<br>• Tom Bartlett, "Dartmouth and Stanford Apologize After a Political-Science Experiment Gone Wrong." *Chronicle of Higher Education*, October 29, 2014. **B** |
| W 3/4 | Catch Up and Review<br>• Due: Homework 3 |
| F 3/6 | **Midterm Exam** |
| M 3/9 | **No Class: Spring Break** |
| W 3/11 | **No Class: Spring Break** |
| F 3/13 | **No Class: Spring Break** |

| | |
|---|---|
| M 3/16 | Understanding Political Science Research Designs<br>• *Watch*: How to Read a Scholarly Article (click through tabs, too)<br>• *Skim*: James Curry and Jason Roberts, 2025. "Interpersonal Relationships, Bipartisanship, and January 6th." *American Political Science Review*. **B** |
| W 3/18 | Introduction to Inferential Statistics<br>• P&E Chapter 8 (pp. 193–196) |
| F 3/20 | Probability Theory and the Central Limit Theorem<br>• P&E Chapter 8 (pp. 196–203)<br>• Charles Wheelan. 2014. *Naked Statistics*, Chapter 8. **B** |
| M 3/23 | Statistical Inference with the Normal Distribution: Z-Scores<br>• *Watch*: Khan Academy, "Z-Scores" |
| W 3/25 | Statistical Inference with the Normal Distribution: Standard Errors<br>• P&E Chapter 8 (pp. 203–209)<br>• Nimra Ejaz, "Standard Error vs Standard Deviation: What's the Difference?" *Career Foundry*, May 11, 2023. |
| F 3/27 | Statistical Inference with the Normal Distribution: Confidence Intervals<br>• P&E Chapter 8 (pp. 209–213)<br>• *Optional*: Khan Academy, "Confidence Intervals" |
| M 3/30 | Statistical Inference with the T-Distribution<br>• P&E Chapter 8 (pp. 213–219)<br>• Due: Homework 4 |
| W 4/1 | One-Sample Significance Tests<br>• P&E Chapter 9 (pp. 230–235) |
| F 4/3 | **No Class: Good Friday Holiday** |
| M 4/6 | Two-Sample Significance Tests<br>• P&E Chapter 9 (pp. 235–244) |
| W 4/8 | Comparing Proportions with Chi-Square Tests<br>• P&E Chapter 10 (pp. 249–259) |
| F 4/10 | Comparing Proportions, Continued<br>• Khan Academy, "Chi-Square Tests"<br>• Due: Homework 5 |
| M 4/13 | Comparing Means with ANOVA<br>• P&E Chapter 10 (pp. 268–273) |

| | |
|---|---|
| W 4/15 | Correlation and Pearson's R<br>• P&E Chapter 11 (pp. 279–285) |
| F 4/17 | Correlation and Bivariate Regression<br>• P&E Chapter 11 (pp. 286–293)<br>• Due: Homework 6 |
| M 4/20 | Correlation and Bivariate Regression, Continued<br>• P&E Chapter 11 (pp. 293–297) |
| W 4/22 | The Multivariate Case in Brief<br>• *Skim*: P&E Chapter 12 (pp. 309–318)<br>• *Skim*: Craig Volden and Alan Wiseman, 2018. "Legislative Effectiveness in the United States Senate." *Journal of Politics*. **B** |
| F 4/24 | **No Class: Midwest Political Science Association Conference** |
| M 4/27 | Data Visualization<br>• https://www.pewresearch.org/short-reads/2025/12/15/our-favorite-data-visualizations-of-2025/ |
| W 4/29 | Spotting Lies in Statistics<br>• https://flowingdata.com/projects/dishonest-charts/<br>• *Browse*: https://viz.wtf/<br>• Due: Homework 7 |
| F 5/1 | Catch Up and Review<br>• N/A |
| W 5/6 | **Final Exam at 8:00am** |